

you safely wait another cycle or opt for a non-AI model? The answer really depends on your use case and priorities. Consider the following scenarios to guide your decision:

- **“I use (or plan to use) a lot of AI tools locally.”** If you’re a developer tinkering with AI models, a content creator using AI-enhanced apps (Photoshop’s generative fills, video editors with AI upscaling, etc.), or simply an enthusiast eager to try features like Windows Copilot’s built-in image generator and voice assistant, then buying an AI-capable laptop now is wise. You’ll benefit immediately from having the NPU accelerate these tasks. For example, with a Copilot+ PC you can use the new Cocreator in Paint to transform sketches into art or do magic edits on photos instantly on your machine, which is either impossible or much slower on older hardware. Early adopters who do have genuine use for on-device AI will find the experience rewarding and somewhat future-proof. In short, if you foresee your laptop doing heavy “cognitive” labour (beyond standard office and web browsing), you should lean towards a model with an NPU sooner than later.
- **“I mostly need a laptop for Office, web, movies, and maybe occasional coding.”** In this case, you’re an average user who doesn’t require local AI acceleration right away. Yes, Windows 11 will gradually infuse AI into features (even Microsoft Office apps are getting AI helpers), but those will often work via the cloud on older PCs – just possibly a bit slower or not as seamlessly integrated. If you’re not in a rush to have everything AI-powered offline, you can wait. In fact, by late 2026, you might get an AI-optimized laptop for much cheaper, or enjoy second-generation NPUs with even better efficiency. Bottomline is simple – if AI features sound nice-to-have but not need-to-have for you today, it’s okay to save some money and stick with a traditional laptop for now. Keep an eye on software updates – if you start hitting a wall where your PC can’t do something important (like a critical app you use adds an AI feature that won’t run without NPU), that’s the time to upgrade.
- **Are you aiming to keep your new laptop for 4-5+ years?** If longevity and future-proofing are big factors, it might be smart to get on the AI-PC bandwagon in 2025. Even if you don’t heavily use AI features today, the tech landscape is clearly moving in that direction. A laptop without an NPU could feel outdated by 2027 when AI integration in everyday software will be even more pervasive. On the other hand, if you upgrade frequently (say every 2-3 years), you could skip this first wave and jump in when the second wave of AI PCs hits with more refined hardware.
- **Consider your budget and trade-offs.** As of 2025, opting for a Copilot+ capable model might mean you’re paying a premium or sacrificing something else (for example, a non-AI laptop at ₹60,000 might offer a nicer display or a better GPU, whereas an AI-ready laptop at that price could have a more basic screen or less graphics muscle because some cost went into the NPU). If your budget is strict, think about what matters

HOW TO CHECK IF A LAPTOP IS COPILOT+ READY

CPU matters: First, look at the CPU model. Copilot+ PCs need a processor with a powerful built-in Neural Processing Unit (NPU), which is an AI engine. Look for specific keywords in the CPU name. For Intel, this will be the Core Ultra branding. For AMD, the latest AI-ready chips have Ryzen AI in the name. If the laptop has a Qualcomm processor, look for the Snapdragon X Elite or Snapdragon X Plus series, as these are designed for Copilot+. Older processors like an Intel Core i7-12500H or AMD Ryzen 7 7730U will not qualify.

Check for NPU details: Next, read the product description for mentions of an NPU. Manufacturers often highlight the presence of an NPU and its performance in tera operations per second (TOPS). Copilot+ requires an NPU with at least 40 TOPS. If the specs mention a “Neural Processing Unit” or a high TOPS number, that’s a strong sign. If there’s no mention of these capabilities, the laptop is likely not Copilot+ ready.

Verify Memory and Storage: Finally, verify the RAM and storage. A Copilot+ PC must have a minimum of 16 GB of RAM and a 256 GB SSD. Any laptop with less memory or storage will not meet the requirements, even if it has an AI-capable processor.

If you’re still unsure, check the manufacturer’s official website or the Microsoft website’s list of Copilot+ PCs for a definitive confirmation.

more for your typical workload. A graphic designer or gamer might prioritize a color-accurate display or a stronger GPU over AI features – in that case, you might hold off on NPUs for this round. Conversely, a student or professional who lives in productivity apps might happily trade a little 3D performance for the convenience of on-device AI assistance in note-taking or research.

In essence, insist on Copilot+ now if it directly aligns with your current needs (or if you love being an early adopter). Otherwise, it’s reasonable to wait a bit – the ecosystem of AI software is still growing, and within a year or two, AI hardware will be more common even in mid-range laptops. By then, you won’t have to choose between an AI engine and other features; you’ll get it all in one package. This Fast Track will help you evaluate those trade-offs in later chapters (for specific use-case recommendations, see Chapter 3’s blueprints). But if you’re on the fence today, a good approach is: don’t buy hype, buy for your use-case. 